

You're sure you do more around the house than they do

8 findings · 12-step checklist · 4 sources · cheatgrid.com

That feeling grows with how big your household is more than with what actually gets done. Certainty about your own tally doesn't make it **an accurate count**.

THE GOAL

You're finding out whether the split is actually fair, not winning an argument. Ask them what they did this week that you might not have noticed.

CHECKLIST

You've just started listing everything you did this week to prove you do more than they do.

- ☐ Before you say your list out loud, ask them: 'What did you do this week that I might not have noticed?'
- ☐ Check whether anything changed this week, like one of you being sick or working late, that would explain the extra load.
- ☐ Write down what they say next to what you already had, so neither list only lives in memory.
- ☐ Go through their list one item at a time, naming each specific thing, not lumping it all together.
- ☐ If they can only name one or two things, ask about a specific day: 'what happened on Tuesday?'
- ☐ If they get defensive partway through, say plainly: 'I'm not saying you do nothing, I'm trying to see what I'm missing.'
- ☐ Skip trying to make both totals add up evenly. Go straight to naming **one task each of you owns** starting today.
- ☐ Write down what you agreed and put it where you'll both see it again, like the fridge or a shared note, dated today.
- ☐ If something besides the chores is bothering you, say that too, in one sentence, before you end the conversation.
- ☐ If this argument keeps happening, name that pattern out loud instead of relitigating tonight's totals.
- ☐ Pick a specific day to check whether the new split is working, not just 'soon.'
- ☐ Before you stop talking, say one specific thing they did this week that you noticed and appreciated.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1 The size of your household changes how sure you feel more than it changes what gets done.
- 2 A defensive reaction from them doesn't mean you've caught them out.
- 3 That discomfort doesn't mean the exercise backfired. It may just mean you're finally seeing a gap in effort you missed before.

Why your own count feels airtight

KNOW

Your own effort is what your memory keeps front and center.

Among married couples studied this way, a more lopsided memory gap went with a bigger overestimate of their own share. [Source 1](#)

KNOW

Most couples land on two different totals when they each estimate their own share of the housework.

In this study, more than seven in ten couples had at least one partner overestimating their own share, and most of the mismatches were mild. [Source 1](#)

KNOW

The size of your household changes how sure you feel more than it changes what gets done.

How much each person contributed barely changed with group size, even though how much they claimed did. [Source 2](#)

The fix everyone reaches for

DO

Go through what they did before your own.

People who named a partner's contributions first ended up claiming less than those who named their own first. [Source 2](#)

DO

Picture them **by name**, doing something specific this week, rather than folding them into 'everyone else who lives here.'

Naming a teammate's specific share of a task first cut people's inflated self-estimates in one study of small teams. [Source 3](#)

WATCH

A defensive reaction from them doesn't mean you've caught them out.

People tend to hear a stated claim of extra credit as calculated instead of as an honest memory gap. [Source 3](#)

What saying it out loud actually costs

KNOW

Comparing lists might settle the tally, but it won't necessarily make you both feel better. In four studies, whoever had contributed the most ended up less pleased with the group and less eager to work together again.

People who'd contributed less didn't take the same hit, and the pattern held most strongly in cooperative, not competitive, groups. [Source 4](#)

KNOW

That discomfort doesn't mean the exercise backfired. It may just mean you're finally seeing a gap in effort you missed before.

The authors only suggest that seeing each other's contributions side by side makes a real gap harder to miss, not that it proves one. [Source 4](#)

Sources

1. [https://web.mit.edu/curhan/www/docs/Articles/biases/37_J_Personality_Social_Psychology_322_\(Ross\).pdf](https://web.mit.edu/curhan/www/docs/Articles/biases/37_J_Personality_Social_Psychology_322_(Ross).pdf)
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Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Sharing the housework at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

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